

Strategic Obfuscation in International Pledgemaking

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October 5, 2026

Abstract

International organizations increasingly rely on pledge-and-review mechanisms to encourage governance reforms, with expectations that information dissemination enhances domestic accountability. However, this paper demonstrates that such organizations can have unintended consequences for international goals. Using a formal model in which leaders simultaneously pledge to an international reporting organization and navigate domestic electoral incentives, the analysis reveals that information dissemination does not beget more ambitious governance reforms. Leaders anticipate how publicized information will affect voter beliefs and, in equilibrium, systematically obfuscate their commitments. Expected governance reforms are no greater in a world with international pledgemaking than in a world without it. Allowing for pledges to carry reputational costs and benefits can change how ambitious governments appear and may sometimes make commitments informative but counterintuitively decreases expected reforms. International reporting therefore faces a fundamental tradeoff: making pledges more informative need not strengthen implementation and may instead weaken domestic accountability it hopes to engender.

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International institutions frequently ask governments to announce their intended policy reforms and then publicize those commitments to domestic and international audiences. Across areas ranging from environmental cooperation to anti-corruption and good governance, leaders submit pledges or national plans that international organizations compile into public reports (Raiser, Çalı and Flachsland 2022).¹ Conventional wisdom holds that, by making a government’s stated ambitions more visible, international reporting can provide voters with a benchmark for evaluating subsequent policy performance (Kelley and Simmons 2015; 2019). Domestic electoral accountability should therefore operate at two stages: voters can hold leaders accountable for implementing their commitments, while the anticipation of such scrutiny should motivate leaders to make pledges that credibly reflect their willingness to reform (Dai 2002; Fang 2008).

This note highlights an underappreciated feature of this conventional logic: international pledges are self-reported and therefore strategically chosen by leaders. This implies that the same electoral concerns expected to motivate later reform also shape what leaders promise in the first place. A leader who expects voters to reward an ambitious pledge has reason to overcommit regardless of her willingness to implement it (Melnick and Smith 2025; Tørstad et al. 2025),² while a leader who expects that commitment to become an electoral liability may instead understate her ambitions. International reporting can provide voters with useful information only if these pledges distinguish leaders who are willing to pursue reform from those seeking the electoral benefits of appearing committed.

To study this problem, I develop a formal model of domestic politics in the shadow of a reporting mechanism run by an international organization (IO). Navigating this dual au-

¹Notable examples include the Paris Agreement, the OECD’s Development Assistance Committee Peer Reviews, the UN Convention Against Corruption’s Implementation Review Mechanism, the World Trade Organization’s Trade Policy Review Mechanism, the Universal Periodic Review of the Human Rights Council, and the International Labor Organization’s Complaint Procedure.

²This is similar to the finding in the international negotiations literature that incumbents have incentives to negotiate “weak treaties” to manage domestic audiences; see Buisseret and Bernhardt (2018); Battaglini and Harstad (2020); Melnick and Smith (2023).

dience (Mitchell 1998; Haftendorn, Keohane and Wallender 1999; Dai 2005), governments engage in a two-stage process to governance. Leaders first make pledges about their willingness to pursue governance reform, which the IO compiles into a public report. Leaders then invest costly effort into reform, producing a policy outcome. The model distinguishes between “aligned” leaders who share the median voter’s preference for governance reform and “misaligned” leaders who are beholden to special interests or engage in corruption and graft, making reforms more costly. A domestic voter observes both the IO report and the policy outcome, and uses them to assess whether the incumbent is aligned before deciding whether to retain her.

The model first considers whether an informative report can change the leader’s effort and then asks whether leaders are willing to make different pledges such that the report is informative. If the two types of leaders were expected to make different pledges, the IO report would help the voter assess the incumbent’s alignment and could motivate greater reform effort following some reports. In such a case, public information could clarify leaders’ willingness to cooperate with international goals (Keohane 1984; Mitchell 2006; Awad and Riquelme 2024). This possibility captures the conventional logic behind international reporting, but it takes the pledge choices that make the report informative as given. I show that once leaders determine their pledges with the report’s electoral consequences in mind, aligned and misaligned leaders make ambitious commitments with the same likelihood. I refer to this as *strategic obfuscation*: equilibrium pledging severs the relationship between what a government promises and its alignment with public views on reform, leaving the IO report uninformative.

The central finding is counterintuitive: leaders obfuscate precisely because the IO publicizes their commitments. Rather than demonstrate their alignment through pledges *ex ante*, leaders prefer to shift the burden of signaling onto downstream policymaking, where costly effort offers a more credible signal to voters. Domestic electoral accountability therefore

motivates costly reform effort without inducing informative pledges, leaving implementation no more ambitious than it would be without international reporting.

Strategic obfuscation emerges from a chase-and-evade logic between leader types (cf. [Roberson 2006](#)). Misaligned leaders seek the electoral protection afforded by pledges associated with alignment, while aligned leaders seek to preserve their informational—and thus electoral—advantage. If voters believe aligned leaders are more likely to make ambitious commitments, misaligned leaders have an incentive to do the same. If ambitious commitments instead become associated with misalignment, aligned leaders distance themselves by making modest pledges, while misaligned leaders abandon the same electorally damaging commitment. Any pledge that would be favorably received by voters consequently attracts both types, while any pledge that invites an unfavorable assessment repels them. Unfortunately, this theoretical logic rules out differences in pledging across types but does not determine empirically how ambitious governments will appear: both types may always make modest pledges, always make ambitious pledges, or randomize between them at the same rate. International reporting may therefore coexist with considerable variation in observed commitments, even though that variation does not reveal leaders’ willingness to reform.

The model’s main result isolates the electoral consequences of pledgemaking by assuming that ambitious and modest commitments have no direct effect on a leader’s payoff. In practice, ambitious pledges may generate international recognition or enhance a government’s reputation ([Falkner 2016](#); [Dubash 2025](#)), but they may also invite naming and shaming or impose political or administrative costs to compile ([Hafner-Burton 2008](#); [Terman 2023](#); [Tørstad and Wiborg 2025](#)). I therefore extend the model to incorporate these additional incentives. Reputational rewards can ensure leaders make ambitious commitments, while reputational costs push them toward more modest pledges. When these incentives are sufficiently strong, all leaders converge on the favored pledge and the IO report remains uninformative. Partially informative pledges are possible only when these incentives are moderate, and even

then pledges never perfectly distinguish aligned leaders from misaligned leaders. But, interestingly, greater information comes at the expense of implementation: whenever pledges are informative of the leader’s alignment, expected reform effort is lower than it would be without international reporting.

Taken together, the results identify a limit to the domestic accountability mechanism underlying international reporting: electoral concerns motivate leaders to undertake costly reform, but the same concerns also shape upstream policy commitments. International reporting is therefore either irrelevant or counterproductive for inspiring greater effort. When pledges are uninformative, reporting does not change expected reforms; when pledges partially reveal alignment given reputational consequences, leaders can rely less on costly implementation to demonstrate alignment and expected effort falls. Paradoxically, the reporting mechanism reduces reform precisely when it succeeds in making commitments informative.

These findings principally speak to established theories about the role of IO information in domestic politics. As IOs are thought to be a more credible source of information dissemination than domestic actors ([Grigorescu 2003](#)), existing work shows how international institutions can provide domestic constituencies with information about government behavior, allowing voters to punish defection and encouraging leaders to comply ([Mansfield, Milner and Rosendorff 2002](#); [Dai 2005](#); [Fang 2008](#); [Chaudoin 2014](#)). However these accounts generally do not model the leader’s strategic disclosure of the very information that IOs disseminate. Domestic politics are not merely a constraint on compliance, but a central driver of what an IO knows, based on the voluntary pledges it receives, and can subsequently broadcast to the public (e.g., [Bayer and Crippa 2025](#)). It is precisely the anticipated effect of this information on domestic political survival that deprives leaders’ commitments of their informational value in the first place.

This distinction also places the argument within research on international benchmarking and performance indicators. Public comparisons can create social pressure by motivating

governments to improve their standing (Kelley and Simmons 2015; 2019). Yet benchmarks can also distort government behavior, as states may substitute effort toward measured areas and away from other priorities (Bisbee et al. 2019); reporting requirements and performance targets can encourage bureaucratic compliance at the expense of meaningful reform (Honig 2018; 2019). These studies show how governments adjust their behavior after a benchmark has been established, but I highlight that strategic obfuscation determines commitments from which benchmarks are constructed.

More broadly, the paper speaks to the work showing that transparency does not unambiguously improve accountability. A robust literature highlights how certain forms of transparency or third-party reporting can create perverse incentives (e.g., Prat 2005; Ashworth and Shotts 2010). Extant work also demonstrates that the dissemination of government information shapes citizen beliefs, collective action, and political survival (Hollyer, Rosendorff and Vreeland 2015; 2018; 2019a); these political consequences give governments reason to control the information that reaches domestic and international audiences, including by suppressing or misrepresenting information supplied to international institutions (Hollyer, Rosendorff and Vreeland 2019b; Carnegie, Clark and Zucker 2024; Carnegie and Clark 2026). The mechanism highlighted here is distinct from information suppression as leaders may be willing to participate and engage with international institutions, though in a way that renders the information disclosed irrelevant for international cooperative goals.

These informational problems also have implications for flexible institutional design. Because rigid agreements are often poorly suited to differences in national circumstances, many international institutions rely on voluntary commitments and reporting requirements (Rosendorff and Milner 2001; Rosendorff 2005; Johns 2014; Linos and Pegram 2016). These arrangements can flexibly facilitate participation and preserve national discretion, although often at the cost of shallower commitments (Downs, Rocke and Barsoom 1998; Gilligan 2004; Edry 2020). They also leave institutions dependent on information that governments choose

to provide. IOs may respond by changing how this information is collected and publicized, including through confidentiality (Stasavage 2004; Carnegie and Carson 2020) or information aggregation and stocktaking (Milkoreit and Haapala 2017). Yet limiting attribution can also weaken the domestic accountability that public reporting is intended to mobilize, creating a tradeoff between protecting the reporting process and making international commitments politically consequential.

Model

I develop a model of domestic politics in the shadow of an international reporting mechanism. There is an incumbent leader (she) and a representative, or median, voter (he). Although I frame the model around a voter to ease exposition, the same logic operates wherever a leader’s hold on office depends on a domestic support coalition that evaluates her commitments and performance, which could be an electorate or a ruling elite (Bueno de Mesquita et al. 2003). The leader determines how much effort $a \in \mathbb{R}_+$ to exert toward costly governance reforms, such as climate mitigation or anti-corruption enforcement.

Leaders vary in the extent to which they are influenced by corrupt or anti-reform special interests, which I parameterize as a marginal cost of pursuing reforms. “Aligned” leaders ($\theta = 1$) produce reform effort at marginal cost $\lambda_1 > 0$, while “misaligned” leaders ($\theta = 0$) act on behalf of special interests seeking to maintain the status quo, effectively raising their marginal costs of policy reform to λ_0 such that $\lambda_0 > \lambda_1$. Thus, aligned leaders are so named because they can exert effort more cheaply into good governance reforms that are favored by the public. Whether a leader is aligned or misaligned is her private information; the voter believes the incumbent is aligned with prior probability $\gamma \in (0, 1)$.

The incumbent leader’s utility comprises a benefit from office-holding $\Psi > 0$ less the costs of pursuing effort toward reform. Without loss of generality, leaders obtain utility

normalized to zero when out of office. The leader’s utility while in office is

$$u_L(a; \theta) = r\Psi - \frac{\lambda_\theta}{2}a^2.$$

Observe that, in the absence of reelection incentives, leaders would not exert effort into good governance reforms, as such effort is costly.

The leader’s reform effort generates a policy outcome, which is observed by the voter, $x = a + \varepsilon$, where $\varepsilon \sim N(0, \frac{1}{\zeta})$. Higher realizations of x are more likely to reflect greater reform effort. The precision parameter ζ measures how clearly the policy outcome reveals the leader’s underlying effort. Substantively the parameter captures factors that help the public connect government action to observed outcomes, like bureaucratic quality (Slough 2024) or monitoring by civil society organizations (Grossman and Michelitch 2018). Throughout I maintain the parameter restriction $\zeta < \frac{\lambda_1 \sqrt{2\pi e}}{\Psi}$, which ensures that each leader’s effort problem is globally concave.

After observing the policy outcome x , the voter decides whether to retain the incumbent or replace her with a challenger, $r \in \{0, 1\}$. If the incumbent is replaced, the challenger is aligned with probability γ . The voter prefers to have aligned leaders in office, and so his payoff is

$$u_V(r) = r\theta + (1 - r)\theta_C,$$

where θ_C is the alignment of the challenger.³

To analyze the effects of international reporting and dissemination of information, I introduce an international organization that receives public commitments and compiles them into a report.⁴ Before exerting reform effort, the leader submits a costless pledge $m \in \{0, 1\}$

³This is equivalent to a two-period model in which the voter’s utility is parameterized over governance outcomes x .

⁴The mechanism may characterize other settings in which costless communication occurs between leaders and their publics, such as campaign promises; I focus on international reporting because IOs are often seen as a more credible, institutionalized channel (Grigorescu 2003) layered atop domestic politics to make com-

to the IO. A pledge of $m = 1$ represents an ambitious commitment to governance reform, while $m = 0$ represents a more modest commitment, or a pledge less dedicated to global good governance goals.

The IO takes this self-reported pledge and publicizes it into a report, defined as $s = m + \nu$, where $\nu \sim N(0, \frac{1}{\tau})$. That the IO's report is a noisy signal of the pledge reflects that IO assessments need not rest solely on governments' self-reported inputs: civil society groups and other actors may also contribute information to the report. I assume these contributions are independent of the leader's type, reflecting, for instance, third parties' own methodologies, priorities, or assessments of external conditions, so that they shift the report without revealing the leader's alignment. The parameter τ then captures the precision of the IO's assessment or measurement capacity: as τ increases, the public report more accurately reflects the ambition of the government's underlying pledge. The IO report s concerns the government's stated ambition, whereas the subsequently observed policy outcome x provides information about its implementation.⁵

In this setup, the IO is modeled as a non-strategic actor that mechanically disseminates the leader's pledge without strategic manipulation. While international organizations in some domains likely possess their own bureaucratic preferences (Fang and Stone 2012), abstracting from IO agency isolates governments' strategic incentives. As we shall see, international reporting can lose its informational value even when the IO faithfully executes its transparency mandate.⁶

The timing of the game is as follows:

mitments more visible. As will be shown, even this channel leaves pledges uninformative, since governments choose what to report with the same electoral concerns in mind.

⁵From a technical perspective, modeling the IO's report s as a continuous signal ensures non-degenerate beliefs about the leader's type on the equilibrium path, allowing for a clean characterization of the equilibrium without relying on complex refinements for off-path beliefs.

⁶IOs need not always act as neutral arbiters of information; the World Bank's Doing Business rankings provide a prominent counterexample. Allowing the IO to manipulate the report would introduce an additional strategic layer, but such manipulation is not necessary for the problem identified here to arise.

1. Nature draws the incumbent leader's type $\theta \in \{0, 1\}$, observed only by the leader.
2. The leader submits a pledge $m \in \{0, 1\}$ to the IO. The IO disseminates the report $s = m + \nu$, which is observed by the leader and the voter.
3. The leader exerts reform effort $a \in \mathbb{R}_+$.
4. The voter observes the IO report s and the domestic policy outcome $x = a + \varepsilon$, and decides whether to retain or replace the incumbent.
5. Payoffs are realized and the game ends.

The solution concept is perfect Bayesian equilibrium. To isolate the effect of the international reporting mechanism on domestic politics, I compare two institutional environments. I first establish a baseline without the IO, in which the voter must infer the leader's type solely from the policy outcome. I then introduce the pledge and reporting stage to analyze how the opportunity to make a public, costless commitment through an international institution affects the leader's reform effort and the voter's electoral strategy.

Analysis

I begin by establishing the baseline equilibrium of the domestic interaction without international reporting. I then introduce the international pledge and reporting mechanism. All formal proofs are relegated to the appendix.

Domestic Accountability

As a benchmark, consider the game without the IO in which the leader only invests in policy effort. The voter uses the observed policy outcome x to infer whether the incumbent is aligned. Let $\mu(x) = P(\theta = 1|x)$ be the voter's posterior belief that the incumbent is

aligned, and $\hat{a}_\theta$ be the voter's conjecture about the leader's effort. By Bayes's rule, the voter retains the incumbent if and only if his posterior belief is greater than the prior probability of drawing an aligned challenger, $\mu(x) \geq \gamma$, which reduces to a simple threshold rule: the voter reelects the incumbent if and only if

$$x \geq \frac{\hat{a}_1 + \hat{a}_0}{2} \equiv \hat{x}(\hat{a}).$$

The leader then knows she will be reelected with probability

$$\pi(a) = \Phi(\sqrt{\zeta}(a - \hat{x}(\hat{a}))),$$

and selects a level of effort given by the first-order condition shown in Proposition 1.

Proposition 1. *In the equilibrium without the international organization, unique optimal efforts a_θ^* solve the first-order condition*

$$\underbrace{\sqrt{\zeta}\phi(\sqrt{\zeta}(\frac{a_1^* - a_0^*}{2}))\Psi}_{\text{marginal electoral benefit}} = \underbrace{\lambda_\theta a_\theta^*}_{\text{marginal effort costs}}.$$

The voter reelects the incumbent if and only if $x \geq \hat{x}(a^)$.*

To determine equilibrium effort levels, leaders balance the marginal electoral value of implementing reforms with the marginal costs of good governance reforms. As aligned leaders have lower marginal costs of effort, they naturally exert more effort than misaligned leaders. Indeed, the first-order conditions imply $\frac{a_1^*}{a_0^*} = \frac{\lambda_0}{\lambda_1} > 1$. Thus, since greater effort translates into better governance outcomes on average, the voter is more likely to conclude that the leader is aligned upon observing a higher value of the policy outcome x . Consequently, better policy outcomes lead to greater odds of reelection.

This baseline establishes that the prospect of enhanced electoral odds motivates invest-

ments into good governance and provides a benchmark upon which we can compare any potential effects of international reporting.

International Reporting

Now introduce the international pledge and reporting mechanism. Before choosing reform effort, the leader submits a pledge m to the IO, which then publishes the report s . The public report provides the voter with an additional potential source of information about the leader's alignment. The central question is whether this information changes the leader's incentives to exert reform effort.

Define $\hat{p}_\theta = P(m = 1|\theta)$ as the voter's conjecture about the probability that leader-type θ sent an ambitious pledge to the IO. The voter's posterior belief now incorporates two pieces of information, the IO's report s and the policy outcome x , and can be written as $\mu(x, s)$. Given voter conjectures $\hat{a}_\theta$ and $\hat{p}_\theta$, it is optimal to retain the incumbent leader whenever:

$$x \geq \frac{\hat{a}_1 + \hat{a}_0}{2} + \frac{\log(\frac{\hat{m}_0(s)}{\hat{m}_1(s)})}{\zeta(\hat{a}_1 - \hat{a}_0)} \equiv \hat{x}(\hat{a}, \hat{p}),$$

where $\hat{m}_\theta(s) = \hat{p}_\theta \phi(\sqrt{\tau}(s - 1)) + (1 - \hat{p}_\theta) \phi(\sqrt{\tau}s)$ is the total probability of observing the IO's report s given type θ .

The first term of the cutoff $\hat{x}(\hat{a}, \hat{p})$ is identical to the first model, but the second term factors in the role of the IO's report into the voter's beliefs about the leader's type. Since the voter now has two pieces of information about the leader—the IO's report and the policy outcome—he assesses outcomes differently. If the voter believes that leaders send $m = 1$ with equal probability, $\hat{p}_1 = \hat{p}_0$, then the IO's report is uninformative and the second term collapses, leaving only the voter's assessment of downstream effort to determine reelection probabilities. In such cases, pledges are not relevant for the leader's effort choice.

If instead the voter believes that the pledge may have been informative about type,

$\hat{p}_1 \neq \hat{p}_0$, the report changes the policy outcome required for retention. Reports that provide favorable evidence about the incumbent's alignment make the voter more lenient, whereas unfavorable reports make the voter more demanding. The direction of this inference depends on the leaders' conjectured pledge strategies. If aligned leaders are more likely to make the ambitious pledge, higher reports favor alignment; if misaligned leaders are more likely to make it, the interpretation reverses.

As in the benchmark model, the voter's threshold induces a probability that the incumbent will be reelected, which generates the motivation for the leader to exert effort into reforms. This reelection probability is equal to

$$\pi(a; \hat{p}) = \Phi(\sqrt{\zeta}(a - \hat{x}(\hat{a}, \hat{p}))),$$

such that optimal efforts $a_\theta^*(\hat{p})$ balance

$$\underbrace{\sqrt{\zeta}\phi(\sqrt{\zeta}(a_\theta^* - \hat{x}(a_\theta^*, \hat{p})))\Psi}_{\text{marginal electoral benefit given report}} = \underbrace{\lambda_\theta a_\theta^*}_{\text{marginal effort costs}}.$$

It is clear from the equation above that the IO's report affects the incumbent's selection of effort through the voter's beliefs about her type. To understand the conventional wisdom surrounding international reporting, it is useful to first analyze the case in which the voter's beliefs about the leader's report are held fixed. If we assume that leaders use different pledging strategies, $\hat{p}_1 \neq \hat{p}_0$, then the IO's report may successfully act as a screening device. Conditional on these informative strategies, international reporting can therefore induce more effort following some report realizations.

Proposition 2. *Let a_θ^* be the equilibrium effort in the model with international reporting, and $\tilde{a}_\theta^*$ be the equilibrium effort without international reporting given by Proposition 1.*

- *If $\hat{p}_1 = \hat{p}_0$, then effort is identical in both models, $a_\theta^* = \tilde{a}_\theta^*$.*

- If $\hat{p}_1 \neq \hat{p}_0$, there exists $\underline{s}_\theta$ and $\bar{s}_\theta$ such that effort is larger in the model with international reporting, $a_\theta^* \geq \tilde{a}_\theta^*$, when $s \in [\underline{s}_\theta, \bar{s}_\theta]$ and larger in the model without international reporting otherwise.

Proposition 2 treats the voter's conjectures about pledgemaking as fixed. It shows that an informative reporting process could alter, and sometimes increase, the leader's subsequent effort. But the conjectures that make reporting informative must themselves be consistent with leaders' optimal pledge choices. Once pledgemaking is strategically determined by leaders, the conventional logic breaks down.

Proposition 3. *In every equilibrium of the model with international reporting:*

- Leaders use identical pledging strategies, $p_1^* = p_0^* = p^*$, such that any common probability $p^* \in [0, 1]$ can be supported in equilibrium.
- The international report is uninformative about the leader's type, and equilibrium effort is identical to that in the domestic benchmark, $a_\theta^* = \tilde{a}_\theta^*$.

How do leaders determine whether to make ambitious or modest commitments? While there are no direct costs to pledging, their equilibrium effects manifest through the voter's posterior beliefs and the subsequent effect on the leader's reelection chances. Define leader-type θ 's equilibrium continuation payoff following report s as

$$V_\theta(s; \hat{p}) = \max_{a \in \mathbb{R}_+} \left\{ \Psi\Phi(\sqrt{\zeta}(a - \hat{x}(\hat{a}, \hat{p}; s))) - \frac{\lambda_\theta}{2}a^2 \right\}.$$

The leader's pledging strategy relies on maximizing this payoff over the distribution of the IO's potential reports:

$$\max_{m \in \{0,1\}} \int_{-\infty}^{\infty} V_\theta(s; \hat{p}) \sqrt{\tau} \phi(\sqrt{\tau}(s - m)) ds.$$

The IO attempts to act as a screening device—separating aligned reformers from misaligned types by creating informative reports. However, leaders anticipate the effect of this information revelation. The key factor is that leaders’ pledges must be mutually consistent with the beliefs the voter holds downstream.

To see why, consider how the IO’s report affects the voter’s retention threshold. Suppose first that the voter believes aligned leaders are more likely than misaligned leaders to make ambitious pledges, $\hat{p}_1 > \hat{p}_0$. A higher IO report then makes the incumbent appear more likely to be aligned, while an unfavorable report leads the voter to demand a better policy outcome before retaining her. Both types consequently want to avoid the electoral penalty associated with an unfavorable report and are drawn toward the ambitious pledge. For the misaligned leader, this means mimicking the pledge associated with alignment. But once both types make that pledge, it can no longer distinguish between them.

Now suppose instead that ambitious pledges are more closely associated with misaligned leaders, $\hat{p}_1 < \hat{p}_0$. The voter’s interpretation reverses, as a favorable IO report now produces a more stringent retention threshold. Both types would prefer a modest pledge. The aligned leader seeks to distance herself from the pledge associated with misalignment, while the misaligned leader wishes to escape the same electoral penalty. Once again, their incentives push them toward the same pledge and eliminate the distinction between types.

The international reporting mechanism therefore creates a chase-and-evade dynamic (cf. [Roberson 2006](#)). Misaligned leaders seek the electoral protection afforded by pledges associated with alignment, while aligned leaders seek to preserve or recover their informational advantage—and thus their *ex ante* electoral edge. Yet as soon as one pledge becomes electorally favorable, both types want to make it. This dynamic echoes classical incentives to misrepresent elsewhere in international politics, where leaders may find it strategically beneficial to overstate their costs or misrepresent their type to achieve a domestic or bargaining advantage ([Fearon 1995](#); [Schultz 1998](#); [Powell 1999](#)).

Given these competing incentives, the only mutually consistent equilibrium is one in which both types use the same pledge strategy, as it is the only means through which both leaders can optimally satisfy their domestic electoral constraints. This condition does not determine how frequently leaders make ambitious pledges—both types may always make modest pledges, always make ambitious pledges, or randomize using any common probability $p^* \in [0, 1]$. In this sense, anything can happen with respect to the observed frequency of ambitious commitments.

Unfortunately, this strategic pooling renders the IO’s report uninformative: the voter completely discounts the report in his assessment of the leader’s alignment, and the equilibrium level of downstream effort reverts exactly to that of the baseline model without the IO. In short, the domestic political survival problem wholly subordinates the international institutional goal. Leaders strategically co-opt the international reporting mechanism to stifle any downstream informational effects, demonstrating that voluntary pledges cannot systematically inspire greater reform effort.

The failure of international reporting to increase effort should not be confused with an absence of electoral accountability, however. The voter continues to observe policy outcomes x and removes incumbents whose performance provides sufficiently unfavorable evidence about their alignment. Leaders continue to exert costly effort in equilibrium; Proposition 3 shows that international reporting does not add to these incentives.

Can Pledges Be Informative?

Proposition 3 demonstrates that international reporting does not increase effort into policy reforms because leaders’ commitments underpinning these reports are uninformative. This result assumes that making an ambitious rather than a modest pledge has no direct effect on the leader’s payoff. In practice, making an ambitious pledge may itself carry costs or benefits. Ambition may generate international recognition or bolster a state’s reputation

(Falkner 2016; Kelley and Simmons 2019); conversely, it may instead create administrative or political costs, expose the government to criticism, or constrain its subsequent rhetoric (Tørstad and Wiborg 2025). To incorporate these possibilities, suppose the leader receives an additional payoff ρm from her pledge:

$$u_L(r, a, m; \theta) = r\Psi - \frac{\lambda_\theta}{2}a^2 + \rho m.$$

A positive ρ represents a net benefit from making the ambitious pledge, while a negative ρ represents a net cost. Importantly, ρ is common to both leader types; I do not assume that ambitious pledges are inherently more costly or credible for one type than the other.⁷ Instead, I ask whether a common institutional or reputational incentive can overcome the strategic obfuscation identified in Proposition 3.

Proposition 4. *In the extended model with the common pledging payoff,*

- *Pooling equilibria always exist. The unique pooling equilibrium is $p_1^* = p_0^* = 1$ if $\rho > 0$ and $p_1^* = p_0^* = 0$ if $\rho < 0$. There exists a bound $\bar{\rho}$ such that if $|\rho| > \bar{\rho}$ then only pooling equilibria exist.*
- *Full separation cannot be sustained in equilibrium. Any partially informative reporting equilibrium requires $|\rho| < \bar{\rho}$ and $p_1^*, p_0^* \in (0, 1)$ with $p_1^* \neq p_0^*$.*
- *In any partially informative equilibrium, expected equilibrium effort is lower than equilibrium effort in the model without the IO,*

$$\frac{E[a_1^*]}{\tilde{a}_1^*} = \frac{E[a_0^*]}{\tilde{a}_0^*} < 1.$$

⁷Allowing the costs or benefits of pledging to vary by leader type could mechanically support separation for appropriate values. But doing so would build into the leader's payoff the very difference in credibility that the model asks whether domestic electoral accountability can generate endogenously.

The main takeaway from Proposition 4 is that adding a common benefit or cost to pledgemaking does not eliminate leaders' incentives to obfuscate. The first result shows that direct incentives to pledge can select among the pooling equilibria characterized in Proposition 3. When ambition carries a benefit, both types make ambitious pledges; when it carries a cost, both make modest pledges. Hence, these incentives can change the rhetoric governments adopt without changing the informativeness of the commitment. Additionally, if the common cost or benefit becomes sufficiently large, it overwhelms the electoral considerations underlying pledgemaking and ensures pooling as the only equilibrium outcome.

Intermediate values of ρ may permit partially informative equilibria, elucidating cases in which pledges can be informative about the leader's alignment. A common cost or benefit can counteract leaders' electoral incentives sufficiently for them to use different pledge probabilities. However, they cannot produce full separation: in any informative equilibrium, both types must continue to use both pledges with positive probability.

Partially informative equilibria, however, carry a counterintuitive implication: although pledges provide information about the leader's alignment, they reduce expected reform effort downstream. The reason is that the IO report begins to perform some of the screening that otherwise occurs through the policy outcome. Once the report provides evidence about the leader's type, the voter relies less heavily on subsequent policy performance to distinguish aligned from misaligned incumbents. For some realizations of the report, the resulting change in the reelection threshold can increase effort. On average, however, informative reports reduce the electoral return to costly reform because fewer reports leave the voter dependent on the policy outcome to learn the leader's type. Greater information at the pledging stage therefore comes at the expense of implementation downstream.

Proposition 4 reveals a tension between the informational and behavioral goals of international reporting. Common reputational incentives can shape what governments promise and may sometimes allow those commitments to be informative. But as pledges become

sharper signals of the leader’s alignment, they also substitute for the costly policy behavior that voters would otherwise use to evaluate incumbents, generating a tradeoff between informative reporting and the downstream effort these pledges intend to engender.

Repeated Electoral Accountability

As is common in models of electoral accountability ([Canes-Wrone, Herron and Shotts 2001](#); [Maskin and Tirole 2004](#)), I only consider a single electoral cycle. In this setting, accountability drives investments into policy effort because poor policy outcomes reduce leaders’ prospects of remaining in office. Proposition 3 shows that *ex ante* pledges do not compound these accountability forces: once leaders choose identical pledging strategies, the IO report provides no additional information and effort returns to its level in the domestic benchmark. A repeated setting introduces a different consideration by allowing the voter’s assessment of a retained incumbent’s alignment to persist across electoral cycles.

To see how this changes the voter’s decision, consider a two-period version of the game and let $q_2 = \mu_1(x_1, s_1)$ denote the probability that a retained incumbent is aligned at the beginning of the second period. Proposition A.1 shows that the voter’s cutoff in a second electoral cycle depends on three components: the effort the voter expects from each type in the second period, the information contained in the second IO report, and the information inherited from the previous cycle. Because retention in the first period implies $q_2 \geq \gamma$, past performance gives the incumbent an initial advantage over a new challenger and, holding current strategies fixed, lowers the policy outcome required for reelection. The consequences for second period effort are nevertheless ambiguous: a change in the retention threshold may either increase or decrease the marginal electoral return to reform, while equilibrium effort and pledging strategies may themselves respond to the incumbent’s past performance (cf. [Ashworth, Bueno de Mesquita and Friedenber](#) 2017). Repetition can therefore change the strength of accountability without necessarily making pledges more informative because

it allows for the persistence of those inferences across cycles, not a new mechanism that automatically disciplines ambitious pledges.

Conclusion

International reporting rests on an intuitive premise: publicizing government commitments should allow domestic audiences to hold leaders accountable for subsequent policy performance. Yet this argument depends on the commitments themselves remaining informative once leaders anticipate how voters will interpret them. This note shows that the very electoral concerns that generate accountability downstream also shape what leaders promise before that effort is observed: pledges that voters associate with alignment attract misaligned leaders seeking electoral protection, while those associated with misalignment repel both types of leaders. Leaders consequently make ambitious commitments with the same likelihood, leaving the IO report uninformative and reform effort no greater than it would be without international reporting.

Giving pledges independent reputational consequences does not necessarily resolve this problem. Strong benefits or costs determine whether governments make ambitious or modest commitments, but they push leaders uniformly toward the favored pledge and leave the report uninformative. More moderate incentives can sometimes make pledges partially informative, although they never allow voters to distinguish perfectly between aligned and misaligned leaders. Moreover, this information comes at the expense of implementation: once the report provides evidence about the leader's alignment, voters rely less heavily on subsequent policy performance, reducing the electoral return to costly reform and decreasing effort on average. Paradoxically, the reporting mechanism reduces reform precisely when it succeeds in making commitments informative.

The model is necessarily stylized, but it is motivated by an essential feature of pledge-

and-review frameworks such as the Paris Agreement and other self-reported governance structures. In addition to implementing policy, governments first choose the ambition of the commitment that will inform later review and public discussion. Nationally determined contributions are recorded publicly and feed into subsequent assessments of collective progress, so leaders select them knowing that international publicization may also shape domestic politics ([Falkner 2016](#); [Raiser et al. 2020](#)). This creates the political problem at the center of the model: leaders must decide what their initial commitments will reveal about their willingness to pursue reform and how voters will interpret later policy performance in light of those commitments. The theory abstracts from the particular features of the Paris regime to isolate this sequence, but a similar structure appears in open government action plans and voluntary national reviews, where governments retain substantial discretion over how they present their intended policies before those plans enter an international process of review and publicization ([Raiser, Çalı and Flachsland 2022](#)). More generally, the mechanism applies wherever governments control the commitments later publicized to domestic audiences, but less directly to benchmarks constructed entirely from independent monitoring or third-party data.

This perspective also guides empirical assessments of the efficacy of international reporting, the value of pledges, and membership into institutions relying on self-reporting frameworks. More ambitious commitments or greater international participation are not by themselves evidence that reporting has strengthened accountability. In fact, the equilibrium analysis implies that, absent independent incentives for pledging, leaders would be exactly indifferent over joining such an agreement and staying out as they are payoff equivalent. That these agreements create large memberships, a fact for which they are often lauded, is therefore not by itself evidence of a commitment to reform. Hence, while these institutions might be an easy means of signing onto international collaborative efforts, they need not imply intentionality toward furthering good governance goals ([Hollyer and Rosendorff](#)

2011). This finding contrasts with scholarship in which signing treaties is a signal of leaders' preferences for cooperation (e.g., [Von Stein 2005](#); [Simmons 2009](#)).

Moreover, where governments control the initial pledge, changes in stated ambition may bear little relationship to subsequent reform effort. Shared reputational rewards may produce widespread ambitious commitments without making them informative. The relevant question is whether the international process changes implementation beyond the domestic incentives leaders already face. Conversely, evidence that pledges predict subsequent behavior need not imply that the reporting mechanism has increased effort overall. The most useful comparisons will therefore examine how the relationship between pledges and subsequent performance changes across institutions that differ in government control over the initial commitment, the amount of independent information introduced during review, and the political consequences attached to the resulting report.

The model focuses on voters because international reporting is often expected to operate through domestic accountability ([Falkner 2016](#)), but international reports routinely address several audiences at once. Civil society organizations can use public comparisons to create reputational pressure, while professional elites may respond through organizational learning, norm diffusion, and peer pressure ([Honig and Weaver 2019](#)). Financial institutions and investors can restrict access to capital when international assessments reveal policy risk ([Morse 2019](#)). The Ease of Doing Business rankings similarly operated through a combination of domestic politics, investor sentiment, and bureaucratic reputation ([Doshi, Kelley and Simmons 2019](#)). When these audiences reward or punish governments for the ambition of their commitments, their influence is captured by the common pledging payoff in the extended model. Strong external incentives uniformly push leaders toward the same commitment, while more moderate incentives may allow pledges to reveal some information but never eliminate leaders' incentives to obfuscate. Different theoretical expectations arise when other audiences possess independent information or condition their responses

on whether governments deliver. Civil society scrutiny, market sanctions, or international rewards tied to implementation could connect the consequences of a pledge more directly to subsequent policy performance. Future research could model these responses explicitly and examine how they interact when international and domestic audiences value different dimensions of government behavior.

The analysis also uncovers a tradeoff in the design of international reporting mechanisms. Pledge-and-review institutions are often expected to make government commitments public so that voters can hold leaders accountable for implementation. Yet the prospect of that accountability is precisely what gives leaders reason to obfuscate when choosing their pledges. Institutional reforms may limit this strategic behavior, but often by weakening the same domestic accountability channel that reporting is intended to mobilize. Confidentiality can encourage more candid disclosure by insulating reports from public political consequences, while collective assessment can reduce the pressure attached to any one government's commitment (Stasavage 2004; Carnegie and Carson 2020). The Paris Agreement's separation of publicly recorded national contributions from a collective assessment of global progress illustrates this tension (Milkoreit and Haapala 2017; Raiser, Çalı and Flachsland 2022; Melnick and Smith 2025). International institutions can insulate disclosure from domestic political pressure or use publicity to mobilize electoral accountability, but this paper highlights that doing both at once is difficult: the political consequences that make reporting consequential also give leaders reason to deprive their commitments of informational value.

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